

Academic Writing (BETA)

Seminar 4



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Lecture recap

1. What food was discussed in the lecture? Why?
2. What is a paragraph?
3. What makes a good paragraph?
4. Should a new paragraph be indicated by leaving a space, indenting, or both?
5. How many paragraphs should the final assignment be?
6. What is the most important sentence of a paragraph?
7. What can the last sentence of a paragraph do?



Today's Programme

- ▶ Paragraph structure & layout
- ▶ Linking language





Paragraph structure

Example paragraph 1

Is this a good paragraph?

- Is there one topic?
- Does the topic sentence announce and cover this topic?
- Is there a logical order?

Jacques (2006) believes that, seeing that “English ranks only second in the world in terms of those who speak it as a first or second language” and that “the present [high] status of English is not necessarily cast in stone”, unlike the most British now seem to think, English is not the *lingua franca*. In order to prove this Jacques illustrates that many more people speak Mandarin, and assumes that in consequence of the rise of China the number of Mandarin-speaking people only will rise. Therefore, in order to be able to communicate all over the world it is not enough to only speak English.



Adapted text from VU-CEAW

Note: these are student texts and there may be some grammar/vocab issues in addition to any issues with structure.

Example paragraph 1 — improved

Jacques (2006) states that in order to be able to communicate all over the world it is not enough to only speak English. He believes that, seeing that “English ranks only second in the world in terms of those who speak it as a first or second language” and that “the present [high] status of English is not necessarily cast in stone”, unlike the most British now seem to think, English is not the *lingua franca*. In order to prove this Jacques illustrates that many more people speak Mandarin, and assumes that in consequence of the rise of China the number of Mandarin-speaking people only will rise.



Example paragraph 2

Is this a good paragraph?

- Is there one topic?
- Does the topic sentence announce and cover this topic?
- Is there a logical order?

Holt (2006), however, opposes this statement. In his opinion, the amount of people speaking Mandarin is outnumbered by the amount of English speaking people if those who speak English as a second language are also included. So he sees it as an advantage to grow up learning English as first language because it is 'the most useful lingua franca anywhere on the planet' (Holt 2006). Nevertheless, he agrees with Jacques that second languages should be taught in schools more intensively again. His experiences as a student and as a teacher have shown that learning a foreign language makes people capable of thinking about language more analytically. The side effect is that they get to know their own mother tongue better. Jacques (2006) adds to this point that as language is also 'the means by which one accesses a culture', learning a foreign language means also learning something about the people from the respective country.



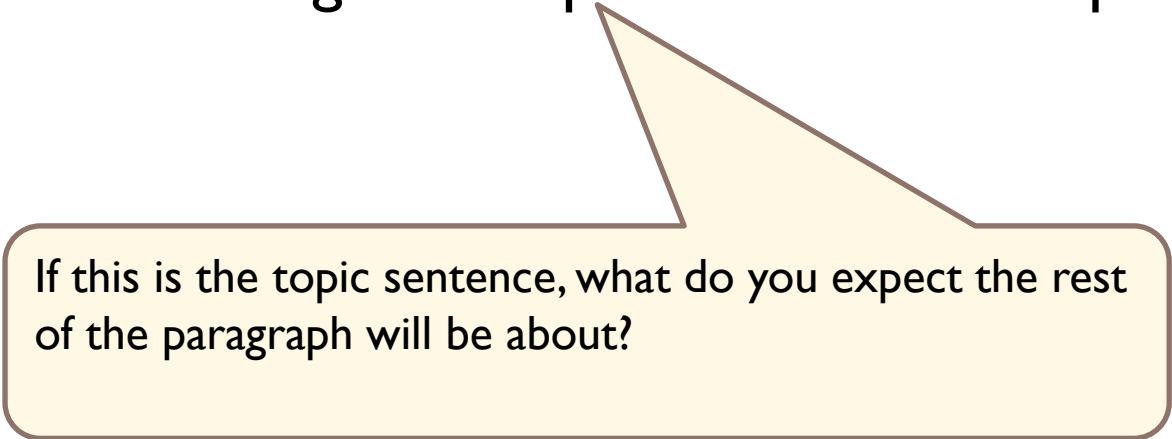
Example paragraph 2 — improved

Holt (2006), however, opposes [the statement that English is not enough]. In his opinion, the amount of people speaking Mandarin is outnumbered by the amount of English speaking people if those who speak English as a second language are also included. So he sees it as an advantage to grow up learning English as first language because it is 'the most useful lingua franca anywhere on the planet' (Holt 2006).

Nevertheless, Holt agrees with Jacques that second languages should be taught in schools more intensively again, because of the benefits of learning second languages. His experiences as a student and as a teacher have shown that learning a foreign language makes people capable of thinking about language more analytically. The side effect is that they get to know their own mother tongue better. Jacques (2006) adds to this point that as language is also 'the means by which one accesses a culture', learning a foreign language means also learning something about the people from the respective country.

Paragraph exercises

Several studies have shown that well-designed robot companions can have significant positive effects on people.



If this is the topic sentence, what do you expect the rest of the paragraph will be about?

Adapted text from VU-CEAW



Note: these are student texts and there may be some grammar/vocab issues in addition to any issues with structure.

Paragraph exercises

Several studies have shown that well designed robot companions can have significant positive effects on people. Wada et al. performed an experiment where the baby seal robot Paro was given to elderly people at a daycare center and they showed that the robot made the users happier [1]. The caretakers also benefitted from the presence of the robot seal, apparently because happier elderly people require less effort from their caretakers and thus the staff became less stressed. Important to note is that the positive effect of Paro did not just come from the novelty factor, but lasted for the duration of the entire experiment, five weeks.

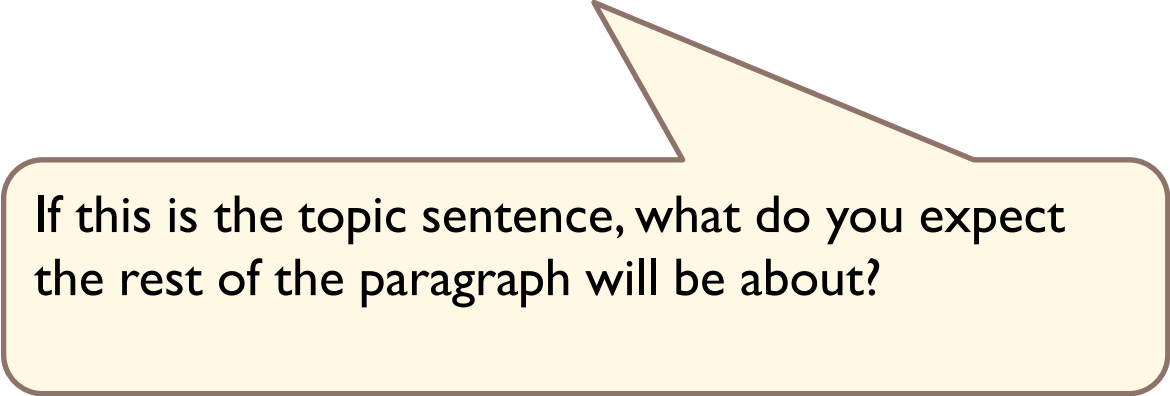
Adapted text from VU-CEAW



Note: these are student texts and there may be some grammar/vocab issues in addition to any issues with structure.

Paragraph exercise

With all these threats in cyber security, there need to be laws that define to which extent networks can be used.



If this is the topic sentence, what do you expect the rest of the paragraph will be about?

Adapted text from VU-CEAW



Note: these are student texts and there may be some grammar/vocab issues in addition to any issues with structure.

Paragraph exercise

With all these threats in cyber security, there need to be laws that define to which extent networks can be used. The internet is a constant changing environment and the boundaries need to be clear. People are against censorship and limiting the internet, but there are certain actions that are not tolerated on the internet. In the dark corners of the internet it is possible to find illegal transactions and people sharing information that nobody should possess (child pornography and government sensitive information for example), which is why there are institutions that monitor the internet and find the perpetrators. Each continent in the world has its own organization against cyber-crime; in Europe the European Union and Europol are the organizations in charge against the cyber-crime threat. The European Economic Community (EEC), which was established in 1992, addresses international crime and cyber-crime by adopting joint positions, directives and instruments. The EEC also focusses on improving security awareness, improving coordination and collaboration between countries and ensuring that technology can be used by law enforcement. Because the internet is large and constantly changing, the EEC also makes sure that the treaties and agreements are up to date.



Adapted text from VU-CEAW

Note: these are student texts and there may be some grammar/vocab issues in addition to any issues with structure.

Paragraph exercises-Handout

Paragraph 1:

_____ .They are complicated in the sense that specific sounds deployed in the service of speech and music are themselves arbitrary and meaningless—it is only through learning that the combinations of these meaningless, simple sounds take on significance, both semantically and emotionally. And they are abstract in the sense that different human societies have developed radically different systems of sound to communicate speech and to create music.



Paragraph exercises- Handout

Paragraph 2:

____. One approach is to use simplified variants that are easier to analyze. For example, Findler worked on and off for 20 years on a poker-playing program for simplified 5-card draw poker [7]. He modeled human cognitive processes and built a program that could learn. The danger with this approach is that simplification can remove the challenging components of the problem that are of interest to AI researchers. A variant of this approach is to look at a subset of the game, and try to address each component in isolation. Several attempts have been made to apply machine learning techniques to individual aspects of poker (some examples include [19,21,6]). The second approach, and the one that we advocate, is to tackle the entire problem: choose a real variant of poker and address all the considerations necessary to build a program that performs at a level comparable to that of the best human players. Clearly this is the most ambitious approach, but also the one that promises the most exciting research opportunities.



Paragraph Exercises Handout: original texts

Paragraph 1:

In a way, speech and music can be construed as the most complicated and abstract perceptual experiences that hearing makes possible....

Paragraph 2:

There are two ways that poker can be used as an interesting testbed for artificial intelligence research....





Paragraph layout

Clear where paragraphs start (indentation), roughly the same length

In Britain, there has been a decline started a discussion in *The Guardian* native English speakers. Holt (2006) second language but there are different arguments.

Holt (2006) states that native English speakers have command of the most useful lingua franca" (Holt, 2006) and considers this an argument for not learning another language. Jacques (2006) has the opinion that staying monolingual is an undesirable attitude. He disagrees with Holt's argument for two reasons. First, there are still many people who do not speak English. Second, English is not the most spoken language; Mandarin has twice as many speakers and English is closely followed by Hindi and Spanish. Furthermore, he argues that the status of English is "not necessarily cast in stone" (Jacques, 2006) and therefore the large number of people speaking English should not be a valid reason not to learn another language. Another language could also help to understand other people and their cultures better, he states, as language expresses culture (Jacques, 2006).

Similar to Jacques, Holt (2006) finds that learning foreign languages has positive advantages. One argument for this is his own experience that this helps understanding one's own language. It also has a benefit on the thinking-process: "[learning another language] helps you to think analytically rather than just instinctively: a skill which all students need to work on, no matter what subject they are studying" (Holt, 2006).

However, Holt (2006) is not satisfied with today's level of foreign language education. He states that students are not stimulated to take languages at school and that language teaching

In Britain, there has been a decline in children taking foreign languages at school. This has started a discussion in *The Guardian* whether learning a second language is still valuable for native English speakers. Holt (2006) and Jacques (2006) both argue in favour of learning a second language but they have different approaches on the matter. This paper describes their arguments. Holt (2006) states that native English speakers "have command of the most useful lingua franca" (Holt, 2006) and considers this as an argument for not learning another language. Jacques (2006) has the opinion that staying monolingual is an undesirable attitude.

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Unbalanced paragraphs

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level of foreign language education. He states that students are not stimulated to take languages at school and that language teaching will suffer from this: "the less of us that study languages the less people there will be qualified to teach them in the future" (Holt, 2006).

Sub paragraph: not allowed

In Britain, there has been a decline in children taking foreign languages at school. This has started a discussion in *The Guardian* whether learning a second language is still valuable for native English speakers. Holt (2006) and Jacques (2006) both argue in favour of learning a second language but they have different approaches on the matter. This paper describes their arguments. Holt (2006) states that native English speakers "have command of the most useful lingua franca" (Holt, 2006) and considers this as an argument for not learning another language. Jacques (2006) has the opinion that staying monolingual is an undesirable attitude.

He disagrees with Holt's argument for two reasons.

First, there are still many people who do not speak English. Second, English is not the world's most spoken language; Mandarin has as many speakers and English is closely followed by Hindi and Spanish. Furthermore, Jacques argues that the status of English is "not necessarily cast in stone" (Jacques, 2006) and therefore the large number of people speaking English could not be a valid reason not to learn another language. Another language could also help to understand other people and their cultures because language expresses a culture (Jacques, 2006). Similar to Jacques, Holt lists several positive advantages. One argument for this is that it is easier to learn one's own language. It also has a benefit on the way you think; it helps you to think analytically rather than just intuitively.

On the other hand, Holt argues that it is important to have a good command of one's own language, no matter what subject they are studying" (Holt, 2006). However, Holt (2006) is not satisfied with today's level of foreign language education. He states that students are not stimulated to take languages at school and that language teaching will suffer from this: "the less of us that study languages the less people there will be qualified to teach them in the future"

**One-sentence paragraph:
not allowed**



Linking language

Linking language

- ▶ Important for coherence and cohesion.
- ▶ Makes your text a text rather than a collection of sentences.
- ▶ Important in academic texts: guiding your reader through the text, making the reading task as easy as possible



Sentence-initial linkers

- ▶ Furthermore, additionally, however, moreover, in this respect
- ▶ **Sentence-initial position**
- ▶ However, the two authors have a different point of view on this subject.
- ▶ **Sentence-medial position**
- ▶ The need to learn a foreign language is, however, not seen in education programs and politics.



Know how to use your linkers

- ▶ If you use a contrastive linker, make sure there really is a contrast (etc.)
- ▶ Know how to translate frequently used Dutch linkers, e.g. *daarom* > *that is why, for that reason*.
- ▶ Beware of false friends, e.g. *thereby/daarbij*
- ▶ Make note of commonly misused linking expressions, such as *besides, at last, on the contrary, hereby*



Categorizing linkers – 6 categories (sequence, contrast, illustration, cause & effect, addition, conclusion)

nevertheless furthermore on the other hand consequently therefore while second for example besides moreover however	instead next on the contrary e.g. thus accordingly as a result in spite of although whereas in this case	then in particular in conclusion to illustrate in contrast unlike additionally in sum finally similarly
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Sequence	Contrast	Illustration
second next then finally	however whereas, while on the other hand although instead in spite of in contrast on the contrary unlike nevertheless	for example e.g. in this case to illustrate in particular
Cause & effect	Addition	Conclusion
as a result consequently thus therefore then (if..., then...) accordingly	furthermore besides moreover additionally similarly	in sum thus in conclusion

Other means: use of adjectives

- Addition: *additional, added, extra, further, supplementary*
 - Contemporary composers face the problem that their music is often very hard to understand on first hearing. An **added** difficulty is that musicians, trained in the classical repertoire, often resist performances of modern pieces.
 - **Another** reason to learn English is that it is the second language in the world.
- ▶ Contrast: *opposite, reverse, contrary, converse*
 - ▶ The **opposite** argument is presented by Smith.
 - ▶ The **reverse** situation exists for PLA composites.



Other means: partial repetition

- ▶ The French language ultimately derives from the Latin of the invading armies that occupied Gaul in the early years of the Christian era. *As well as being a Latin-based language*, French has many words that have been borrowed from the Gauls' Germanic neighbours.

BUT: avoid too much metalanguage in the essays for this course:

- ▶ *Having discussed [...], we will now turn to the following question: [...].*
- ▶ *Now that we have seen that [x], we can turn to [y].*
- ▶ *In the previous paragraph I have discussed [...]*



Other means: combining clauses

- A text with only short sentences becomes ‘choppy’; more like a list than a text, so:
- Combine smaller ideas into a bigger idea
 - The train was delayed. However, I was still in time for my class.
 - The train was delayed, but I was still in time for my class.
- Use so-called subordinators to combine sentences (one part is background or support for the main statement):
 - Although the train was delayed, I was still in time for my class.
- Use relative clauses (*who, which, that*) to include background info, like definitions
 - Facebook, which is a social media platform, has more than 2 billion users.



Linking exercise – Handout

- ▶ Exercise 3. Linking
- ▶ The text contains only simple sentences and the relations between the sentences are not clearly expressed. Rewrite the paragraph adding appropriate linking devices, combining sentences, and anything you like to improve the clarity and cohesion.



Social media text: unlinked version

The vast majority of people use social media nowadays. Almost everyone is familiar with the concept. For teens it is one of the most important ways to stay in touch with their peers. 93% of all teens reports the use of social media. Social media is a generic term for all applications and sites that enable social interaction. Examples are Facebook and Twitter. Twitter is a platform where users can post messages with a maximum of 140 characters. Those messages can be retweeted by other users. This is done by forwarding the tweet. The messages are known as tweets.



Social media text: linkers added by ChatGPT

The vast majority of people use social media nowadays; however, almost everyone is familiar with the concept. For teens, it is one of the most important ways to stay in touch with their peers; consequently, 93% of all teens report the use of social media. Social media, a generic term for all applications and sites that enable social interaction, includes platforms such as Facebook and Twitter. Twitter, a platform where users can post messages with a maximum of 140 characters, allows for the retweeting of messages by other users, effectively forwarding the tweet. These messages are known as tweets.



Social media text : improved version

Today, the vast majority of people use social media, a generic term for all applications and sites that enable social interaction, such as Twitter and Facebook. Twitter is a platform where users can post messages with a maximum of 140 characters. These messages, known as tweets, can be shared or 'retweeted' by other users. While almost everyone is familiar with these platforms, for teens they are one of the most important ways to stay in touch with their peers: 93% of all teens report the use of social media.



Social media text: one sentence (overdoing it)

The vast majority of people nowadays use social media, with almost everyone familiar with the concept, especially for teens who consider it one of the most important ways to stay in touch with their peers, as reported by 93% of all teens; social media encompasses all applications and sites facilitating social interaction, including examples like Facebook and Twitter, the latter being a platform enabling users to post messages with a maximum of 140 characters, known as tweets, which can be retweeted by other users, forwarding the tweet to a wider audience.





AI Writing Tools

AI Writing Tools

- What have you used AI writing tools for?
- What are some pros and cons of using them for writing?



Generative tool vs. Editing tool

- Useful applications as a generative tool in general:
 - ▶ Better at some things than humans (e.g. creating a long list)
 - ▶ Brainstorming and summarising (if you can verify the information)
- Limitations as a generative tool on this course:
 - ▶ We are looking for a real representation of your thinking process, and a more sophisticated analysis than a summary of two articles (two articles in dialogue)
 - ▶ We are interested in writing as part of the thinking process (development of relevant cognitive and critical skills)
 - ▶ If you use a tool like ChatGPT, where does information come from and is it reliable?
 - ▶ Hallucination of sources:

Liu, C. (2020). The impact of AI on higher education. International Journal of Educational Technology in Higher Education, 17(1), 1-10. <https://doi.org/10.1186/s41239-020-00213-6>

- Applications as an editing tool on this course:
 - ▶ We do think AI writing tools offer some interesting educational opportunities.



Assignment 2 due on Friday

Assignment 2

- ▶ Write an introduction paragraph and a first body paragraph for your final paper in which you see how 2-5 academic papers are in dialogue with each other.
 - ▶ The text should be written in a third-person perspective (*Smith* describes, concludes, points out etc.)
 - ▶ Apart from the introduction and first body paragraph, write a few sentences each on (i) how you plan to develop the paper further, and (ii) on what you want to learn from this assignment. You can include one or two specific aspects you want feedback on in particular from your instructor (this isn't counted in the word count).
 - ▶ The text should contain 400 words, 10% margin.
 - ▶ Include your reference list (this isn't counted in the word count)
 - ▶ Do not use AI writing tools to generate the content.
 - ▶ The text will be graded on the following aspects:
 - ▶ Linguistic range and accuracy: grammar, vocabulary, punctuation
 - ▶ Academic style: appropriate level of formality, use of academic idiom
 - ▶ Use of sources: indication and incorporation of sources in the text; use of referencing style; no traces of plagiarism
 - ▶ Deadline: Friday 25 April, by the end of the day.
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